Teaching disciplinary conventions

Are disciplinary conventions visible?

WHAT IS IT?

Hidden disciplinary conventions are surfaced and unpacked using examples

WHY DOES IT MATTER?

University contains many hidden rules: what “critical analysis” means, what a rubric is really asking for, when it is acceptable to ask for help, or what counts as “professional” behaviour. If those rules remain unspoken, familiarity can be mistaken for capability.

THE STUDENT EXPERIENCE

- “Everyone else seems to know rules nobody has explained.”
- “I understand the topic, but not what I am being asked to do.”

HOW CAN I DO IT?

- Show what the convention looks like and why it exists.
- Use annotated examples to reveal the thinking behind a finished product.
- Compare weak and strong versions to make tacit judgement visible.

EXAMPLE IN PRACTICE

Instead of simply asking for a lab report, the educator shows an annotated section and explains what counts as good evidence use.

STARTING POINT TO ADAPT

In this course, we aim to teach disciplinary conventions explicitly and show students how experts use them. If the way a class or learning activity is organised makes it harder for you to participate or understand what is…

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